wrestled with his Jewish identity in Germany and throughout Europe. Freed was born in 1929 and grew up Brooklyn, New York. His parents, Sam and Rose, were both born to Jewish families in Minsk, Russia, but met and married after they emigrated to the United States, escaping a wave of pogroms in their native land around World War I. His older brother, Milton, served as a pilot in the U.S. Air Force, flying missions over the Pacific theater in World War II. Leonard, too young to be drafted during that war, instead was compelled to leave the United States in the years afterward to encounter the legacies of global conflict. Starting in 1952, in his early twenties, Freed traveled through Europe and North Africa for two years. After going home briefly to the United States, he returned to Europe in 1956. He honed his craft as a documentary photographer and supported himself by selling photographs to local magazines and newspapers. Freed sought to further understand his Jewish heritage in the context of post–World War II Europe.

Freed had begun photographing in Germany on his first trip to Europe, focused especially on its landscapes of memory and reconstruction. On his second trip, in 1956, he met a German woman, Brigitte Klück, and his work was first published by Klück's hometown newspaper in Dortmund under the headline "Eine Amerikaner sieht unsere Stadt" (An American sees our city). In 1957 Leonard and Brigitte married in Amsterdam. He thought of the idea for his first book, *Joden van Amsterdam* (*Jews of Amsterdam*) (1958), after visiting the Anne Frank House. Early in 1961 Freed started photographing in neighboring Cold War Germany for a project that would later cohere into his second book, *Deutsche Juden heute* (*German Jews Today*) (1965). Both publications were released in Europe, accompanied by texts in their respective national tongues. Postwar Europe was a puzzle for Freed: a land of great artistic civilization, familial aura, Jewish trauma and estrangement, postwar destruction, and potential redemption. In his mind Germany was the central and most jagged piece of the whole.[3]

The legacy of conflict in Germany weighed on Freed in August 1961, when he took a train from Amsterdam to West Berlin. Freed arrived with his close friend Dutch journalist Willem Oltmans on or around August 25. Neither man had an assignment or a particular itinerary. As many around the world waited on edge for the breakout of World War III, Freed and Oltmans stepped close to the border. Freed's photographs and recollections from that trip found in Oltmans's private journals attest to their movements near